

FREE RESOURCE // THE MASTER OF MUSIC INDUSTRY

How to Pitch to Record Labels (And Get a Response)

Most pitches get ignored in the first 10 seconds. This guide covers what A&R; reps actually look for, how to format your pitch, and how to position yourself as an artist worth signing — before you send a single email.

// WHAT A&R; ACTUALLY LOOKS AT FIRST

Here's the uncomfortable truth: A&R; reps make decisions before they hear a single note. They're evaluating your business case first. Here's the order they actually look:

- 1 Your Streaming Profile**
Monthly listener count, save rate, and listener-to-follower ratio. A 10% save rate is strong. Below 3% is a red flag. They want to see upward trajectory — not necessarily huge numbers.
- 2 Social Media Consistency**
Not follower count — posting frequency and engagement rate. 10,000 engaged followers beats 100,000 ghost followers every time. Labels want to see you can build and hold attention.
- 3 Your Story and Brand**
Is there a clear, compelling narrative? What makes you different from the 10 artists they already have on the roster who sound like you?
- 4 Live Performance History**
Have you played shows? Opened for bigger acts? Sold out a venue, even a small one? Live proof of demand matters enormously.
- 5 Then They Listen**
After all of the above checks out, they press play. Your music has to be exceptional — but by this point it just has to confirm what the data already suggested.

// BUILDING YOUR PITCH DOCUMENT

Your pitch should be a single PDF or well-designed email — never more than one page. Here is exactly what to include:

WHAT TO INCLUDE

- Artist name, genre, and location

Be specific with genre — "indie" is not a genre. "Indie folk with bedroom pop production" is.

- One-sentence artist description

The "for fans of X meets Y" formula works: "For fans of Frank Ocean meets Kendrick Lamar"

- Key metrics: monthly listeners, social following, email list size

Only include numbers that help you. If your Spotify is weak but your TikTok is strong, lead with TikTok.

- 3 best tracks — linked, not attached

Use a private SoundCloud or Dropbox link. Never send MP3 attachments.

- Notable achievements

Sync placements, press features, sold-out shows, viral moments — anything that signals momentum

- Brief bio (3-4 sentences maximum)

- Your ask — be specific

"I am looking for distribution and marketing support for my upcoming EP" is better than "I want a deal"

WHAT NOT TO INCLUDE

- Comparisons to The Beatles, Michael Jackson, or any legend — it reads as delusional

- Negative comments about other artists or previous labels

- Your entire life story — save it for the interview

- Flowery language about how special your music is — let the music speak

- Requests for NDAs before they can listen

- More than 3 tracks — curate ruthlessly

// FINDING THE RIGHT CONTACT

Never cold email the generic label address. Find the specific A&R; rep who signs artists in your genre. Here's how:

1

LinkedIn Research

Search "[Label Name] A&R;" on LinkedIn. Most A&R; reps have public profiles. Look for who has signed artists similar to you in the last 2 years.

2

Spotify Credits

Open albums from artists on that label. Check the credits section — the A&R; rep is often listed. Search their name.

3

Music Conference Networking

SXSW, A3C, ADE, ASCAP Expo — A&R; reps attend these specifically to discover artists. This is the highest-value way to get in front of them.

4

Warm Introduction

The most effective path: get introduced through a producer, manager, or attorney who already has a relationship. Industry relationships are currency.

5

Manager First

Many labels will not consider unsigned artists without management. Getting a credible manager often opens label doors automatically.

// THE FOLLOW-UP STRATEGY

One follow-up email is acceptable. Two is the maximum. Here is the timeline:

Day 1: Send initial pitch

Day 10: One follow-up — brief, no guilt-tripping. "Wanted to make sure this landed in your inbox. Happy to send anything additional."

Day 21: Final follow-up only if you have new news (a sync placement, a viral moment, a sold-out show). New momentum justifies re-engagement.

After that: Move on. Keep building. Labels sign artists they've seen grow — being rejected today does not mean rejected forever.

"The best leverage you can have in any label negotiation is not needing them."